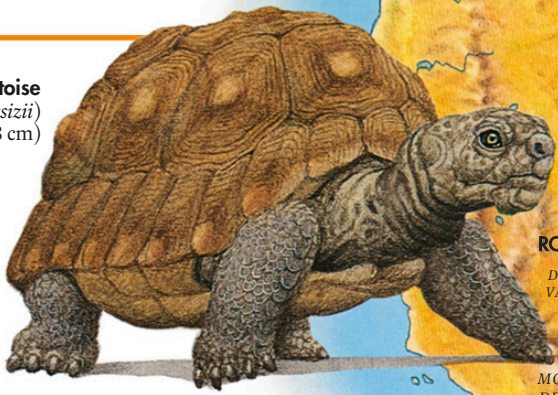


Agassiz's desert tortoise
(*Gopherus agassizii*)
Total length: up to 15 in (38 cm)



Armor plating

The desert tortoise has a hard shell that protects it from the harsh sun. If the tortoise draws its head and legs into the shell, it is hard for an enemy, such as a fox or a bobcat, to reach its soft body. The tortoise uses its flat front legs to dig its underground burrow.



Gila woodpecker
(*Melanerpes uropygialis*)
Length: up to 9.5 in (24 cm)

Cool nest

The gila woodpecker hollows out a nest in the stem of a cactus, such as the giant saguaro. The temperature inside a cactus is much cooler than outside, and the sharp spines on the cactus protect the nest from enemies. If the woodpecker abandons its nest, another bird, such as the tiny elf owl, may take it over.

Sunbather

The common collared lizard hides in rock crevices at night and comes out in the early morning to bask in the sun. The male collared lizard, below, is more brightly colored than the female, but a female carrying fertilized eggs develops red patches on her body.



Common collared lizard
(*Crotaphytus collaris*)
Length: up to 14 in (36 cm)

Desert spider

The desert tarantula is a type of spider. It hides away for most of the day under a stone or in a hole, and comes out at dawn or dusk to hunt for food or find a mate. Although the tarantula is poisonous, its venom is no stronger than a bee sting and it rarely attacks people.



Desert tarantula
(*Aphonopelma chalcodes*)
Length: up to 2.7 in (6.8 cm)

Fatty tail

The gila monster stores fat in its tail. It uses this as a source of energy when other food is hard to find. The colors and patterns on a gila monster's skin warn enemies that it is venomous. It produces venom in its lower jaw and passes this into its victims when it bites them.



Gila monster
(*Heloderma suspectum*)
Length: up to 1 ft 10 in (55 cm)

NORTH AMERICA

GREAT BASIN

ROADRUNNER

DEATH VALLEY

KIT FOX

MOJAVE DESERT

SONORAN DESERT

GILA WOODPECKER

DESERT SWALLOWTAIL

COMMON COLLARED LIZARD

AGASSIZ'S DESERT TORTOISE

GILA MONSTER

WESTERN SPOTTED SKUNK

WESTERN DIAMONDBACK RATTLESNAKE

CACTUS WREN

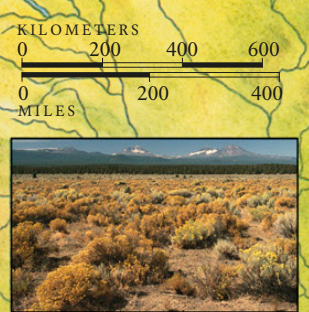
BLACK-TAILED JACKRABBIT

DESERT TARANTULA

GULF OF MEXICO



In summer, the average daytime temperature in Death Valley is often more than 120°F (49°C).



Creosote and sagebrush bushes are two of the most common desert plants.



The saguaro cactus can be up to 50 ft (15 m) high and weigh more than an African elephant.

Black-tailed jackrabbit

(*Lepus californicus*)
Body length: up to 24 in (61 cm)
Ears: up to 5 in (13 cm)

Leaps and bounds

The black-tailed jackrabbit has powerful back legs and can bound across the desert at speeds of up to 35 mph (56 kph). This helps it escape from coyotes and other enemies. Its huge ears pick up sounds of danger and help it keep cool by giving off heat.

